

CSE5IDP Week 10 — The Path Home: Usability, SFIA and Career Readiness

Lecture summary · Scott Mann · Semester 2, 2026

Milestone 4 opens — Thursday 24 September 2026

At a glance

A short and unusual session. The first 25 minutes of the recording are the online room waiting while the on-campus usability trial finished in the Agora (the audio there is corridor chatter, a Leafy AI student walking through a point-cloud plant-detection idea, and a Mac-versus-Windows debate). Scott resumed at about the 27-minute mark and lectured for roughly an hour. Online attendees named at the close were Elsin, Firoz and Maya. The content fell into four parts:

1. **How to treat usability feedback** — a roadmap for the project owner, not a to-do list for your last two sprints.
2. **“The path home”** — where the semester is, what the final two to three weeks demand, and the professionalism and AI-use expectations that come with them.
3. **SFIA** (Skills Framework for the Information Age) — the framework Scott built the SILOs on, and the language he wants your CV written in. This was the bulk of the session.
4. **Career-readiness practices** — public GitHub, testimonials, reflective journaling, Gibbs and STAR, certifications.

Then, after formally ending the session, a face-to-face team asked about a project owner who had just tried to change the architecture in week 10. Scott’s answer is worth reading.

“It’s a tool, it’s not a substitute. And you guys have the skills to evaluate the output, so you need to do that.”

Housekeeping

- **Usability trial for the online cohort.** Scott will work with Ali to run an online usability session, probably next week, using breakout rooms so people can trial each other’s systems and collect feedback. Details will go on the LMS. Bring something that runs.
- **Scrum master presentations.** Confirmed in the pre-lecture chat: once every team member has presented once, no further presentations are needed even if you run seven or eight sprints. You keep sprinting; you just stop presenting. Scott again championed **short sprints** as the

more efficient pattern.

- **Next week's lecture is a CV clinic.** Two hours of Scott reviewing resumes against SFIA. See the homework below — it is the one concrete deliverable from this session.
- **Final presentations** (weeks 12–13) will be face-to-face or online depending on the project owner. Leafy AI will present in the lab in front of the vertical farm; remote project owners mean an online presentation. Be prepared for either.
- **Public holiday Friday 25 September** (AFL Grand Final eve), which disrupts the Friday labs.
- Scott's office is TLC 214 and he intends to be there next year — his standing offer to come back for advice after graduation.

Usability feedback: roadmap, not mandate

Scott opened with a framing he clearly wanted everyone to take home. The usability trial produced a list of recommendations. **Do not go home and try to implement them all.** You still have a plan for your final sprints; execute the plan. The usability output belongs in the handover as a description of who tested the system and what they recommended.

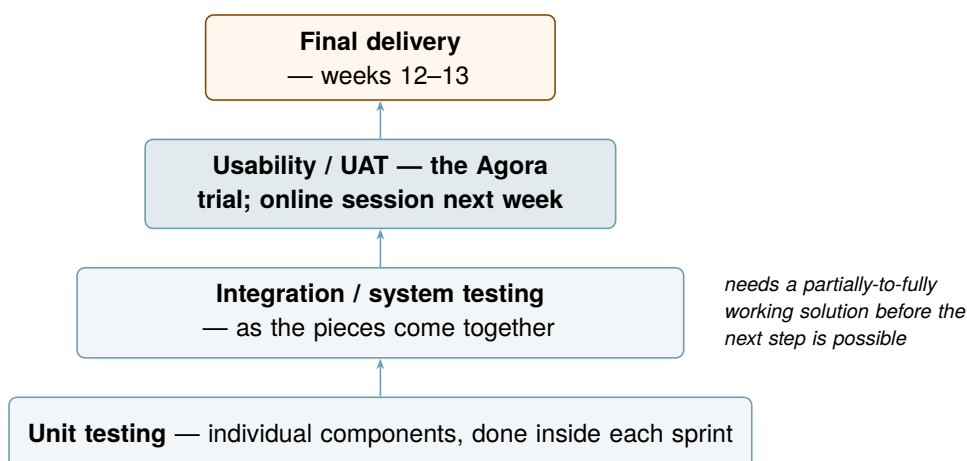
His reason is practical: the question project owners ask him most after handover is “*where do we go from here?*” A usability-derived starting point answers that. It makes his life easier, it makes the owner's life easier, and — as he said in Week 9 — it earns you an extra chapter in the SMD.

Second point: the trial means your system has now been seen by real people. Going into a final presentation where the project owner is seeing the system for the first time is “scary stuff”; that barrier is now cleared.

The path home

Where we are

Milestone 4 has started. Most teams have one or two sprints left. His summary of the journey so far: requirements (which for some teams took a long time), the trade show, design, three to four implementation sprints producing visible componentry, unit testing of components, and now — as the pieces come together — broader **system and integration testing**. The usability trial sits at the top of that tree: you cannot do user acceptance testing without a partially-to-fully working solution.



He acknowledged that most teams still have functions to implement, and that balancing the last of the build, the documentation, and coordinating a six-person team around a project owner presentation is where the final weeks get tricky. The goodwill and motivation visible at the trial is what carries teams through what he called a “somewhat difficult two to three weeks.”

What the final weeks are graded on

Restated plainly: the week 12–13 deliverables are a **high grade of communication and a high grade of documentation quality** — SMD, user document, the GitHub repository, and the final presentation. Confidence in that presentation comes from having kept the project owner informed all semester. If the final presentation is the first the owner has heard from you in eight weeks, “that’s a little bit risky.”

AI, professionalism and ethics

Three threads he tied together:

- **AI writes the syntax; you own the judgement.** Coding in 30-odd languages is now largely automated. What master’s students bring is a first-principles understanding that lets them *evaluate* AI output. Not running a human filter over AI-generated material is “a very dangerous game to play”; at research level it reduces you to “somebody who glues concepts together.”
- **Professionalism** is attendance, participation, accountability to teammates, and doing your assigned Jira tasks when they are due.
- **Ethics** — he sees it more at undergraduate level, but named it directly: pumping out purely AI-generated work, ticking Done in Jira, and expecting the team to accept it is not professional and not ethical teamwork.

And the meta-skill: **the ability to learn.** Have a set of news sites, follow what the tech giants and consulting firms are spending on, and treat lifelong, reflective, adaptive learning as the key marker of a career in ICT.

SFIA — speaking the employer’s language

Why it matters

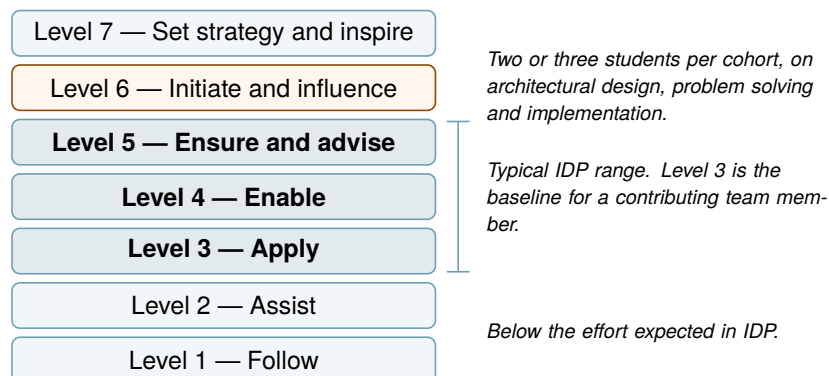
Note on the transcript: the auto-captioning renders it as “Sophia” throughout. It is **SFIA**, the Skills Framework for the Information Age, at sfia-online.org. **SFIA 9** is the current version (SFIA 10 exists); the lecture slides are based on SFIA 9.

Scott’s argument: HR departments and recruiters use SFIA to write job descriptions. A CV that lists “C, Java, PHP, Python, worked in teams, full-stack” is generic keywords. A CV written in SFIA terms has a one-to-one mapping to what the employer scoped, which he claims moves you from sending 20–30 applications and hearing back from five, to sending five to ten with a much better hit rate. “Make yourself the most obvious choice for that position by talking in the same language as your employer.”

He also revealed that **the CSE5IDP SILOs were built on SFIA’s skills mapping** — requirements gathering, system design, agile collaboration, testing and validation, client presentation each map to a SFIA skill at a mid-to-upper level. That is the hook: your IDP work is already SFIA-shaped; you just have to describe it that way.

The framework in two dimensions

Seven responsibility levels, from *follow* (1) to *set strategy, inspire, mobilise* (7). Each level is described in terms of autonomy, influence, complexity, business skills and knowledge. In IDP you should sit in the **3 to 5 band**; anyone at 2 or below “is probably not putting in the right level of effort.”



His readings of the levels that matter for you:

Level	SFIA name	What it looks like in IDP
3	Apply	Complex, sometimes non-routine tasks using standard methods; works under general direction; manages own work to deadlines; proactively enhances skills. The baseline.
4	Enable	Diverse, complex activities and supports and guides others — the member who mentored the team through Git and version control is the example he gave.
5	Ensure, advise	Authoritative guidance in the field, very little direction, sets the pace and direction of the project, accountable for significant outcomes from analysis through execution to evaluation.
6	Initiate, influence	Significant organisational influence, high-level decisions, leadership, accepts accountability in key areas. Rare; he named two or three students in this cohort.

Six skill categories: strategy and architecture; change and transformation; development and implementation; delivery and operation; people and skills; relationships and engagement. His 2026 position: a graduate needs skills across **all six**, not just development and implementation. “You can’t survive just being a developer working on code bases day to day.”

On top of the skills sit **professional attributes** — leadership, collaboration, decision making, security-privacy-ethics, creativity and adaptability, reliability, punctuality, accountability, responsiveness to feedback. These are the soft skills employers probe in interviews, and for cyber roles the security-privacy-ethics set in particular.

The task: a user story of your skills

His instruction, repeated several times:

1. Pick **one or two subcategories per major category** that resonate with what you did in IDP.
2. Assign yourself a **level** in each, and be honest.
3. Evidence each one from IDP — the architectural decision you drove, the tools you used, the working outcome — and structure it under SFIA’s attributes: autonomy, influence, complexity, business skills, knowledge. “This is taking your skill set into a user story.”
4. Build that into a **portfolio**: perhaps five pages of SFIA examples for your major skills, with a

cheat sheet for IDP and links to the code.

Before publishing anything, go back to the project owner and ask how much of the project you may describe publicly.

Homework for next week

Bring your resume, printed, on paper. Update it first so that what you used and did in IDP is mapped to SFIA 9. You do not need to map your whole career — IDP alone is fine as the starting point. Scott will take it, tell you what is right and wrong, and place your contributions at a level. He noted attendance for this session is usually about five times higher than a normal lecture, and said those who come to class get priority — online included.

Career-readiness practices

Evidence and endorsements

- **Public GitHub.** Only one or two hands went up for a public profile with several contributions. He would teach this in the first week of first year if he could. Five visible projects is enough; it lets a technical recruiter gauge you in minutes.
- **Personal domain and portfolio site,** linking out to GitHub and LinkedIn and carrying a SFIA capability matrix. He described this as personal marketing, and noted SFIA also covers science and engineering, so bioinformaticians and animal scientists are not left out.
- **Recommendation letters and testimonials.** Ask your project owner for a page or so at the end of the project. Scott will write one too — for a small subset only: teams that come first and students who have participated well all semester. Ask him **before the Engineering and IT Showcase.**
- A recurring warning: sometimes an excellent student sits in a team that is not. Those students still shine and are still memorable to the project owner. Shoot for number one regardless.

What the compendium is actually marking

Restated: the compendium is individual, and what he and the marking staff look for is **improvement across sprints** — becoming more productive, burning through more per sprint, trying different agile techniques that made the team work easier. Not a record of activity; a record of getting better.

Reflective journaling

Ten minutes a day, before bed. His pitch was as much about wellbeing as career: it concentrates thought and quiets the noise; over a career it builds “a train line from point A to point B” with every step recorded. He started at 43 and regrets not starting in his twenties. Two formal frameworks were shown:

Framework	Structure	When to use it
Gibbs reflective cycle	Six stages: description, feelings, evaluation, analysis, conclusion, action plan — what happened, how you felt, what went well and badly, what else you could have done, what you will do next time	Sprint retrospectives, journaling, the compendium

Framework	Structure	When to use it
STAR	Situation, Task, Action, Result — what happened, who was involved, what you were trying to achieve, what steps you took and why, what the outcome was	Job interviews; “super big in the Australian employment context”

His worked STAR example, aimed squarely at the DevSecOps material from Weeks 8–9: *Situation* — manual regression testing was slowing sprint cycles. *Task* — automate the repetitive test cases without losing accuracy. *Action* — introduced a test script wired into GitHub Actions so every push triggered API endpoint tests. *Result* — testing time down 70 per cent, reliability score up, workflow adopted by the team. “That is an employee I would wish to take in as a company owner, for sure.” Prepare two or three stories like this once you have graduated.

Certifications

Yes, with caveats. Employers do not know the syllabus of a Master of IT or Master of Cyber, but they know exactly what is on the CCNA, AZ-900 or Security+. His pairings:

- Telco, networking, security: **CCNA**, **CompTIA Security+**.
- Cloud: at least practitioner level in **AWS** and **Azure Fundamentals**.
- AI certifications are “smart money” whatever your role.
- Data science: **Microsoft Power Platform** (Power BI, Power Apps), which he described as near standard for delivering visualisation to the C-suite; Tableau also.

The caveats: certifications cost, most require recertification every two to three years, and irrelevant ones burn time and money. This is why the certification pathway sits on the first rubric row of the scrum master presentation — he wants you thinking about it before graduation, not after.

Post-session Q&A: the project owner who moved the goalposts

After ending the session, a face-to-face team (integrating a “war room” system with ERPNext, two systems built by different groups in Semester 1) reported that their project owner had suggested the day before that they **embed the war room inside ERPNext as a module** instead of integrating the two — contradicting the original requirement, in week 10, with the must-haves already delivered.

Scott’s answer, which generalises to any team facing late scope drift:

- Continue on the path you are on and finish it. “You have my blessing to do that.”
- **Do not re-architect.** “You have no time to rearchitect your solution. I don’t want you to burn out.”
- Write a **one-to-two page future-work chapter**: based on your experience, this is how we think an embedded solution could be done, and why we did not have time. You are the people who have seen both systems, so your recommendation is worth more than a fresh team’s guess. That is knowledge transfer, and that is what the handover is for.
- You are graded on doing the process correctly, not on satisfying a week-10 change. The owner has other teams to compare and will likely run another development cycle next semester.
- “Don’t be disheartened. This is normal project work.”

Action items

Immediate

1. **Update your resume and print it** for next week's session. Map your IDP contribution to SFIA 9: one or two subcategories per major category, a level for each, and IDP evidence underneath. Read the SFIA 9 orientation material and the resources at the bottom of the SFIA 9 page first.
2. **Watch the LMS for the online usability session** Scott is organising with Ali. Have a working, demonstrable build ready to put in front of another team in a breakout room.
3. **Do not divert your remaining sprints to usability fixes.** Log the feedback, keep your plan, and reserve the recommendations for the SMD.

Before handover

4. **Add a usability chapter to the SMD:** who tested, what they found, what they recommended, presented as the project owner's starting roadmap.
5. **Add a future-work chapter** for anything the project owner raised late or anything you de-scoped — one to two pages, written from the vantage point of the team that knows the system best.
6. **Keep the project owner informed** between now and the final presentation. Weekly status in the Teams channel at minimum.
7. **Confirm the final presentation format** (online or face-to-face) with the project owner and Scott, and that an academic can attend for live grading.
8. **Ask for testimonials** — the project owner at handover, Scott before the Showcase.

Career housekeeping

9. Make at least a few repositories or a profile README public on GitHub, once the project owner confirms what may be shown.
10. Start a ten-minute daily reflective journal; use Gibbs for retrospectives and draft two or three STAR stories from IDP.
11. Pick one or two certifications that match your target roles and note recertification cost.

Observations for the LJA

- **SFIA is the answer to an open question.** The team has been carrying “should an existing competency framework anchor the cluster labels?” as an item for Scott. He has now said, in a lecture, that the CSE5IDP SILOs were themselves built from SFIA skill mappings. That makes SFIA a natural candidate for anchoring the LJA's competency clusters: rubric criterion → SILO → SFIA skill and level. Worth raising with him directly, since the SILOs already carry an implicit SFIA level (“mid-range and upper”) that a gap detector could report against.
- **The LJA is a SFIA evidence generator.** Scott's ask of students — describe your skills as a user story with evidence at a level — is exactly what a longitudinal competency export could produce for a student. That is a strong framing for the final presentation and the user document: the dashboard output is portfolio material, not just an at-risk flag.
- **Usability chapter.** The online usability session is the LJA's chance to put the student dashboard in front of people who are, in fact, the target user. Capture the feedback with a short structured form (task, what they expected, what happened, what they would change) so it

drops straight into the SMD chapter.

- **Future-work chapter is already half-written.** The in-semester triggering question, the assessor-feedback sanitisation question, the criterion-to-competency inference target, and any LLM-provider governance constraints are all items for a one-to-two page future-work section, written in the voice of the team that knows the pipeline.
- **The STAR example is ours to tell.** A synthetic-data evaluation harness with seeded runs and a quotable correlation range, plus any CI wiring from the DevSecOps material, is a ready-made “showed initiative in improving a process” story for interviews — and a compendium narrative of improvement across sprints.
- **Scott is both lecturer and project owner.** The post-session advice — do not re-architect in week 10, write future work instead — is his own stated position. If any late suggestion arrives from the LJA side, that is the response he has pre-approved.